# Assassins

## By Stephen Sondheim and John Weidman

*Suggested Roles* ***Actor 1:*** *Booth and Radio Announcer (shared)*
***Actor 2:*** *Herold, Voice, Oswald, and Radio Announcer (shared)*

***NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.***

**(Pg 15)** *A tobacco barn in rural Virginia – middle of the night. Booth sits huddled on the floor, drinking from a brandy bottle and reading through a pile of newspapers.*

**BOOTH:** **(Pg 17-19)** Damn! *(takes a tattered diary out of his pocket and starts to write. The door bangs open and* *******David Herold rushes in)*

**HEROLD:** They're coming! They'll be here any minute! *(begins frantically gathering their things. Booth throws down his pen; his hand is trembling)*

**BOOTH:** I need your help. I've got to write this and I can't hold the pen!

**HEROLD:** Johnny, they've found us! We've got to get out of here!

**BOOTH:** Not till I finish this. Have you seen these papers?! Do you know what they're calling me?! A common cutthroat! A hired assassin! This one says I'm mad!

**HEROLD:** We must have been mad to think we could kill the President and get away with it!

**BOOTH:** We did get away with it! He was a bloody tyrant and we brought him down! And I will not have history think I did it for a bag of gold or in some kind of rabid fit!

**HEROLD:** Johnny, we have to go --

**BOOTH:** No! I have to make my case. Take it down. *(Booth holds out the diary and the pen and dictates as Herold writes)* An indictment. Of the former President of the United States, Abraham Lincoln, who is herein charged with the following High Crimes and Misdemeanors- One: That you did ruthlessly provoke a war between the States which cost some six hundred thousand of my countrymen their lives. Two: That you did silence your critics in the North by hurling them into prison without benefit of charge or trial. Three-

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**VOICE FROM OUTSIDE BARN:** Booth! I have fifty soldiers out here, Booth! Give yourselves up or we'll set fire to the barn!

**HEROLD:** Don't shoot! I'm coming out! *(throws down the diary and rushes out the door)*

**BOOTH:** No! *(to audience)* I have given up my life for one act, you understand? Do not let history rob me of its meaning. Pass on the truth! Please . . . *(to soldiers outside the barn)* Hunt me down, smear my name, say I did it for the fame . . . What I did was kill the man who killed my country!

## INTRODUCTION

***ACTOR 2:*** *To paraphrase the words of author Blake Crouch: What if time is an illusion, a construct made of human memory?*
***ACTOR 1:*** *What if there's no such thing as the past, the present or the future? What if It's all happening now?*
***ACTOR 2:*** *What if John Wilkes Booth could come face to face with Lee Harvey Oswald, two men forever tied to the assassinations of American presidents. Booth, full of self-righteous conviction:*
***ACTOR 1:*** *(as Booth)* ***Sic semper tyrannis!***
***ACTOR 2:*** *And Oswald, who many Americans still believe did not act alone:(as Oswald)* ***"My definition of democracy: The right to be in a minority and not be suppressed."***
***ACTOR 1:*** *What would Booth say to Oswald in the minutes leading up to . . .*
***ACTOR 2:*** *(voice of radio announcer)* ***Breaking News: Shots fired from the Texas School Book Depository.***
***ACTOR 1:*** *Is history a twisted game of chance or one inevitable destiny where those who feel abandoned and disenfranchised simply find a gun.*
***TOGETHER:*** *Assassins by Stephen Sondheim and John Weidman*

**(Pg 90 – 95)** *A storeroom on the sixth floor of the Texas School Book Depository in Dallas, Texas. Lee Harvey Oswald sits on a carton reading a handwritten note. On the floor beside him are a lunch pail and a long package wrapped in a blanket. An announcer comes on the radio*

**RADIO ANNOUNCER:** That was the Blue Ridge Boys and "Heartache Serenade." And now we take you live to KTEX reporter Harry-

*Oswald turns off the radio as he re-reads the note. He opens the lunch pail, takes out a gun and puts it to his head. Whistling off stage. Oswald spins around. John Wilkes Booth steps onstage.*

**BOOTH:** Oh! I'm sorry. I was just browsing. Please, carry on . . . *(notices the gun. Oswald shoves it back in the lunch pail. Booth indicates a wall clock)* Is that the right time? Yes? *(taking out*

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*a pocket watch)* I don't know what's the matter with this thing. Excuse me for a moment. *(crosses to the radio and turns it on)*

**RADIO ANNOUNCER:** -- speaking to you from Love Field, where the President's plane has just touched down and is taxiing toward us. We understand the President intends to speak briefly at the airport before proceeding into Dallas, where- *(Oswald turns it off )*

**BOOTH:** *(picks up the note, reads)* Dearest Marina. Today I end my life so that your life can begin. Last night you said that I oppressed you . . .

**OSWALD:** *(Oswald snatches the note)* F*** you.

**BOOTH:** We seem to have gotten off on the wrong foot here. *(Oswald grabs lunch pail)* You're not going, are you? *(Oswald heads for the door)* Don't leave now. Come on, I didn't mean to . . . ***Alik***. *(Oswald stops)*

**OSWALD:** What did you call me?

**BOOTH:** Alik. You used to like that nickname. Back in Minsk. Marina said Lee sounded Chinese, so she called you Alik. Of course I don't have to call you Alik. I just thought . . .

**OSWALD:** How do you know what Marina called me?

**BOOTH:** I know lots about you, Lee. Let's see. . . *(rattling it off like a resume)* Born, New Orleans, October 18, 1939. Father, Robert, died before your birth. Crazy mother, Marguerite. Dropped out of school at seventeen. Joined the Marines. Court-martialed twice. Defected to the Soviet Union, October, 1959. Defected back, June, 1962. Married, Marina Nikolaevna. Two children, June and Rachel. Current employment, stock boy, Texas School Book Depository, Dallas, Texas . . . Oh. And this morning, depressed over your estrangement from a wife who views you as a dismal and pathetic failure, you rose before dawn, kissed your sleeping children, put your last hundred dollars and your wedding ring into a cup which Marina's mother gave you for a wedding present, and came here to kill yourself . . .

**OSWALD:** Who are you?

**BOOTH:** I'm your friend, Lee.

**OSWALD:** I don't have any friends. *(beat)* Show me your badge.

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**BOOTH:** My what?

**OSWALD:** You bastards think you're so smart. I know my rights. You try to interrogate me at my place of business I can sue you for harassment.

**BOOTH:** Ah! You think I'm with the FBI!

**OSWALD:** I have a right to see your badge.

**BOOTH:** *(opens his coat, holds out his arms)* Search me, Lee. You think I've got a badge. Come on, search me. *(Oswald starts to frisk him. Booth grins)* The FBI. You really love those morons, don't you? Hell, why wouldn't you? No one else cares if you live or die, those guys can't get enough of you. "How was your day, Lee? Sell any secrets to the Soviets? Sabotage any defense plants? Kick off your shoes and tell us all about it!"

**OSWALD:** *(shoving him away)* F*** you, whoever you are!

**BOOTH:** *(smiles)* I'm sorry, Lee. It's just so sad . . . I mean, it's all you ever wanted, isn't it? Someone who wants to hear about your day. Someone – ***anyone*** -- Your mother. Mother Russia. The Marines. Your wife Marina . . . *(shakes his head)* Attention must be paid.

**OSWALD:** What's that mean?

**BOOTH:** It's from a play. About a salesman. A man very much like you, Lee. independent, proud, a decent man who tries and tries but never gets a break. So, he does something dumb. When he realizes his whole life has been a failure built on lies, he kills himself. And when he's dead, his wife stands at his grave and says ***attention must be paid***. She has to beg the world to pay attention to this poor, misguided nobody . . . I'm an actor, Lee; a good one. But Willy Loman is a part that I could never play. And I don't think that you should play it either.

**OSWALD:** *(beat)* I don't know what you're talking about.

**BOOTH:** What do you want, Lee?

**OSWALD:** You know so much, why don't you tell me?

**BOOTH:** You want what everybody wants. To be appreciated. To be valued. You want someone to love you, Lee. Right? . . . Isn't that it? . . . Lee?

**OSWALD:** Yes.

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**BOOTH:** [Well], forget it. It's never going to happen. It's a fantasy. You've got to give it up.

**OSWALD:** I'm going to kill myself! Don't you think I've given it up?!

**BOOTH:** No. I think you're going to kill yourself because you think that's how to get it. "When I'm dead, then they'll be sorry! When I'm dead they'll know how much they loved me!" When you close your eyes you probably see the funeral, don't you, Lee? A gentle rain is falling. Everybody has umbrellas-

**OSWALD:** Shut up!

**BOOTH:** There's Marina, weeping quietly. Your sobbing children clutching at her skirt. Your mom, your dad. Every boss who ever fired you . . . I'm sorry, Lee. It's just so ***childish***. It's so ***dumb.***

**OSWALD:** You think it's *dumb?!* If I shouldn't kill myself what *should* I do?! Go home?! Beg her to take me back?! Plead with her?! Beat her up?!

**BOOTH:** You tried all that. It doesn't work.

**OSWALD:** I know it doesn't work! So tell me what I ***should*** do!

**BOOTH:** You should kill the President of the United States.

**OSWALD:** What?

**BOOTH:** He's coming into town to make a speech. His plane landed at the airport 15 minutes ago. His motorcade is going to go right past this window. When it does, you shoot him.

**OSWALD:** You're nuts. I didn't come here to shoot the President.

**BOOTH:** He didn't come here to get shot. . . All your life you've been a victim, Lee. A victim of indifference and neglect. Of your mother's scorn, your wife's contempt, of Soviet stupidity, American injustice. You've finally had enough, so how are you planning to get even?

**OSWALD:** I'm not a murderer.

**BOOTH:** Who said you were?

**OSWALD:** You just said I should kill the President . . .

**BOOTH:** Lee, when you kill a President, it isn't murder. Murder is a tawdry little crime; it's born of greed, or lust, or liquor. Adulterers and shopkeepers get murdered. But when a President gets killed, when Julius Caesar got killed . . . he was ***assassinated***. And the man who did it

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*(lets the sentence hang, unfinished)*

**OSWALD:** Brutus.

**BOOTH:** Ah! You know his name. Brutus assassinated Caesar 2000 years ago, and here's a high school drop-out with a dollar twenty-five an hour job in Dallas, Texas who knows who he was. And they say fame is fleeting . . . *(smiles; Oswald stares at him. beat)*

**OSWALD:** This is stupid. Up here on the sixth floor, what would I do? Throw schoolbooks at him?

**BOOTH:** What's in the package that you brought to work? *(indicating package wrapped in blanket)* What's in it?

**OSWALD:** Curtain rods.

**BOOTH:** *(picking up the package)* You sure?

**OSWALD:** Sure I'm sure. Marina wanted me to take them to the . . . *(Booth tosses the package to Oswald; Oswald catches it, looks surprised. He folds back the blanket, revealing a high-powered rifle)*

**BOOTH:** That's a Mannlicher-Carcano. 6.5 millimeter. Stopping range, nine hundred yards. The sight's already been adjusted.

**OSWALD:** Who are you?

**BOOTH:** My name is John Wilkes Booth.

**OSWALD:** John Wilkes Booth shot Abraham Lincoln.

**BOOTH:** *(quietly, smiling)* Attention has been paid . . . All your life you've wanted to be part of something, Lee. You're finally going to get your wish. *(Oswald drops the rifle and turns to leave, Booth blocks his exit)* **(Pg 97)** OK, OK . . . Lee, I'm sorry. I know things are happening kind of fast here. But you can't leave now. You have a responsibility here, Lee.

**OSWALD:** To who? To you? I'm responsible to ***me*** and no one else!

**BOOTH:** Not anymore, Lee. Fifty years from now they'll still be arguing about the grassy knoll, the mafia, some Cuban crouched behind a stockade fence, but right here, right now -- this is the real conspiracy. And you're a part of it.

**OSWALD:** Get out of my way.

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**BOOTH:** *(holding his ground)* You have to do this. Now. You won't get another chance.

**OSWALD:** So what? I'll do something else. I'll shoot my wife. I'll shoot my kids. I won't shoot anyone! Who cares?!

**BOOTH:** *(Exploding)* I care, you stupid fool! Sorry. I'm sorry . . . **(Pg 98)** Take a look, Lee. *(indicating scene outside)* You know what that is? That's America. The Land Where Any Kid Can Grow Up to Be President. But in here *(taps Lee's chest)*, this is America, too. . . "The mass of men lead lives of quiet desperation." An American said that. And he was right. But let me tell you something. There are no lives of quiet desperation here. Desperation, yes. But quiet? Not today. Today we're going to make a joyful noise. You're the one that's going to sum it all up and blow it all wide open. Why, after you . . . *(pauses)* **(Pg 99)** I've seen the future, Lee. And you are it. *(snaps his fingers; the radio comes on)*

**RADIO ANNOUNCER:** -- and now the motorcade is turning into Elm Street. There's someone holding up a banner, "All the Way with JFK." The President is smiling and waving as his car heads for Dealy Plaza where it will swing past the Texas Book Depository - *(Booth snaps his fingers again; the radio goes off. He opens the window, picks up the gun and holds it out)*

**OSWALD:** People will hate me.

**BOOTH:** They'll hate you with a passion, Lee. Imagine people having passionate feelings about Lee Harvey Oswald . . .

**OSWALD:** *(reaches for the gun, hesitates, then drops his hand)*

**BOOTH:** **(Pg 101)** All you have to do is move your little finger -- you can close the New York Stock Exchange. You have the power of Pandora's Box, Lee. Open it . . . *(holds out the gun. Oswald takes it.)* I envy you . . . *(Oswald turns and crouches at the window)* **(Pg 102)** All you have to do is squeeze your finger. Squeeze your finger . . . You can change the wor --

*Oswald fires. Booth exits. Oswald turns. Where did he go? Oswals lurches to his feet, grabs his lunch pail and exits. A beat, then Booth returns. He picks up Oswald's suicide note, takes matches from his pocket and burns it.)*

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author:  Stephen Sondheim and John Weidman***
***ISBN:  978-1559360388***
***Publisher: Theatre Communications Group***
***Date (Month/Year): Sept 1991***

## AWARD HISTORY

***2006 National Qualifier***
***2007 National Qualifier***
***2015 National Qualifier***
***2019 National Qualifier***
***2022 National Qualifier***
***2023 National Qualifier – MS***
***NIETOC***
***IL State Qualifier***
***KS State Qualifier***
***MN State Qualifier***

** David Edgar Herold (June 16, 1842 – July 7, 1865) was an American pharmacist's assistant and accomplice of John Wilkes Booth in the assassination of Abraham Lincoln on April 14, 1865. After the shooting, Herold remained with Booth until the authorities cornered them in a barn.*

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